

Thirty-five paintings

2019–2026 · ISTANBUL, MILAN AND LUXEMBOURG

Paintings since 2019

Thirty-five works made since 2019 across Istanbul, Milan and Luxembourg: acrylic on canvas, on carton and on paper, and one drawing in charcoal on the reverse of a canvas. They are given here newest first, and a small figure with crossed eyes runs through them from one end of the seven years to the other.

MEDIUM
ACRYLIC ON CANVAS, ON CARTON AND ON
PAPER, AND ONE DRAWING IN CHARCOAL

ORDER
NEWEST FIRST, SO THE SEVEN YEARS ARE
READ BACKWARDS

RIGHTS
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THIRTY-FIVE WORKS

NEWEST FIRST

In Özen's paintings a body appears as rounded units settle on top of one another. The contour arrives late and often does not arrive. Scale gives the verdict. A shape held large enough becomes somebody, and the same shape beside it becomes a row. Most of the ground stays unpainted, and that emptiness decides how far the figure gets to build.

The same parts have been turning up since the beginning. A figure present in the scene and not looking. A chair nobody sits in. A frame drawn over the scene and left open. A bird that arrives under its own power, carrying something never unwrapped. These are working parts. Nothing in them waits to be solved. The one helping and the one crushing are made of the same heap.

Titles do not name the picture. A greeting, a game, a file name, a line taken from elsewhere. They set a second language beside the image and tilt it. Decisions are taken in wet paint, colour is held as a distribution. Over the years the parts stay where they are and the temperature changes.



THE STUDIO, LUXEMBOURG · THE GROUND
WORKED FLAT WITH A KNIFE BEFORE ANY FIGURE
IS FOUND



COLO ATTACK ON MANDARIN - THE PALE FORM AGAINST THE SCRAPED GROUND. THE BLUE ONLY AT THE TOP



01 · 7 FAM BOARD GAME · OPPOSITE · THE RIGHT PLAYER'S HEAD — WARM AND COOL LEVEL AT ABOUT A THIRD EACH, CYAN THE LARGEST FAMILY



THE SOURCE — INGMAR BERGMAN, THE SEVENTH SEAL, 1957 · A GAME PLAYED AGAINST SOMETHING THAT DOES NOT LOSE. COPYRIGHT REMAINS WITH THE RIGHTS HOLDER





THE BOARD FROM THE LEFT · EVERY CONE WRAPPED, EVERY HEAD MARKED OUT



Virgil on Virtual Cage (final_ final-finalV9)

ACRYLIC ON CANVAS · 80 × 100 CM · 31 ½ × 39 ⅞ IN · 2026 · LUXEMBOURG

The cage is drawn, not built. A few white lines lay a ceiling across the top and drop two uprights, then stop two fifths of the way down, so nothing is actually shut in. Underneath, the bodies are soft, pressed from the tube and scratched while still wet, and not one of them looks at the lines. The title carries a guide out of the underworld and a file name that has been saved as final nine times over: two promises of an ending, made by something that has none.

COLOUR — THREE QUARTERS WARM, COOL UNDER FOUR PER CENT, THE WHITE WIG THE LIGHTEST POINT

COMPOSITION — A WHITE LINED BOX THAT PROMISES TO ENCLOSE AND STOPS AT TWO FIFTHS OF THE HEIGHT

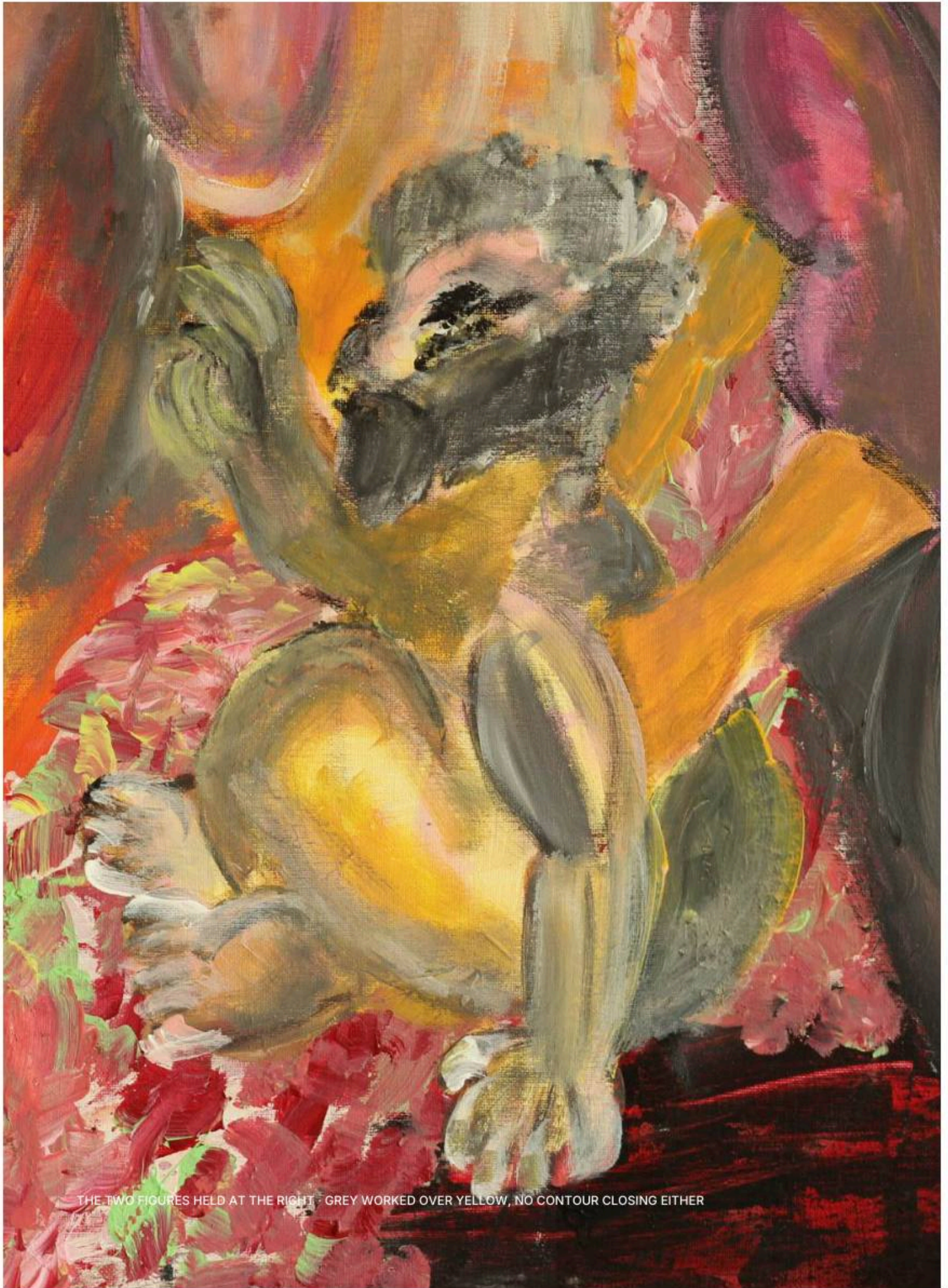
HAND — GRAINY PINK PRESSED FROM THE TUBE AND SCRATCHED WHILE WET, AGAINST FLAT OPAQUE LINE



THE SCENE ENTIRE • THE CANOPY LAID IN WHITE LINE AND LEFT OPEN



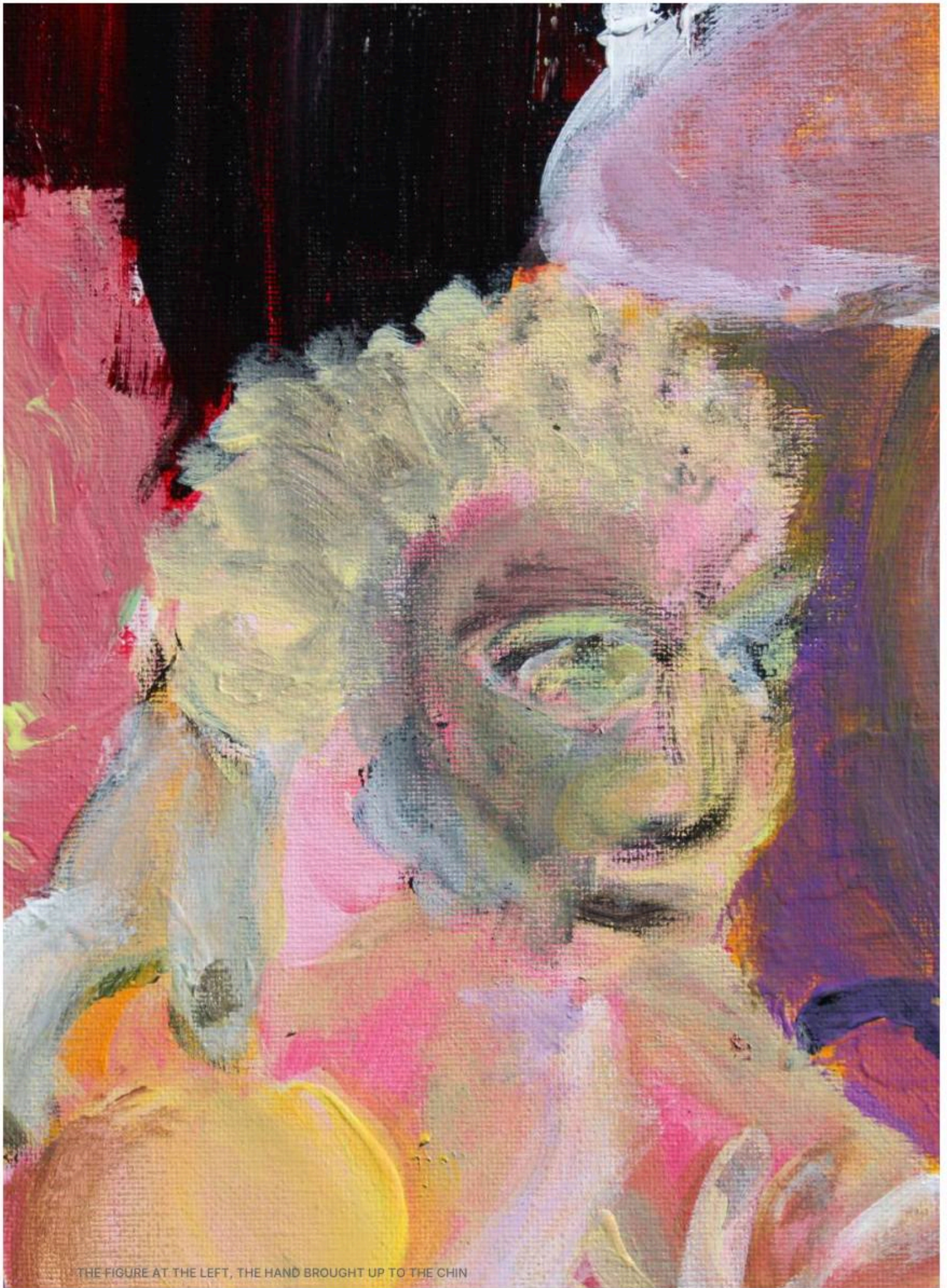
THE HEAD UNDER THE WIG - YELLOW DRESS, BUT A GROOM KEPT DARK



THE TWO FIGURES HELD AT THE RIGHT - GREY WORKED OVER YELLOW, NO CONTOUR CLOSING EITHER

A head under a yellow wig, and opposite it a second,
greener face; neither is given a contour that closes.

BOX DRAWN OVER THE TOP — THREE QUARTERS WARM, COOL UNDER FOUR PER CENT



THE FIGURE AT THE LEFT, THE HAND BROUGHT UP TO THE CHIN



RED GROUND · ONE FLAT LAYER, THEN THE STROKES AND ACCESS



THE WINGED FIGURE, AND THE PAIR CARRIED BENEATH IT

A cage drawn from above, its walls never arriving; a chair outlined where no one will sit.



THE CAGE FROM ABOVE - THE WHITE LINE STOPS BEFORE IT CLOSSES



THE CHAIR DRAWN ON THE PINK PANEL



THE FAR CORNER OF THE SAME CEILING



STAGE 2 — THE LEONARDO CARRIED THROUGH IN PENCIL, THE WHOLE COMPOSITION BEFORE ANY COLOUR



OF 13 STAGES, 5 · IN ORDER

STAGE 3 — THE GROUND DROWNED IN RED, THE FIGURE LEFT AS BARE CANVAS INSIDE IT



THE PAN AT THE LOWER LEFT

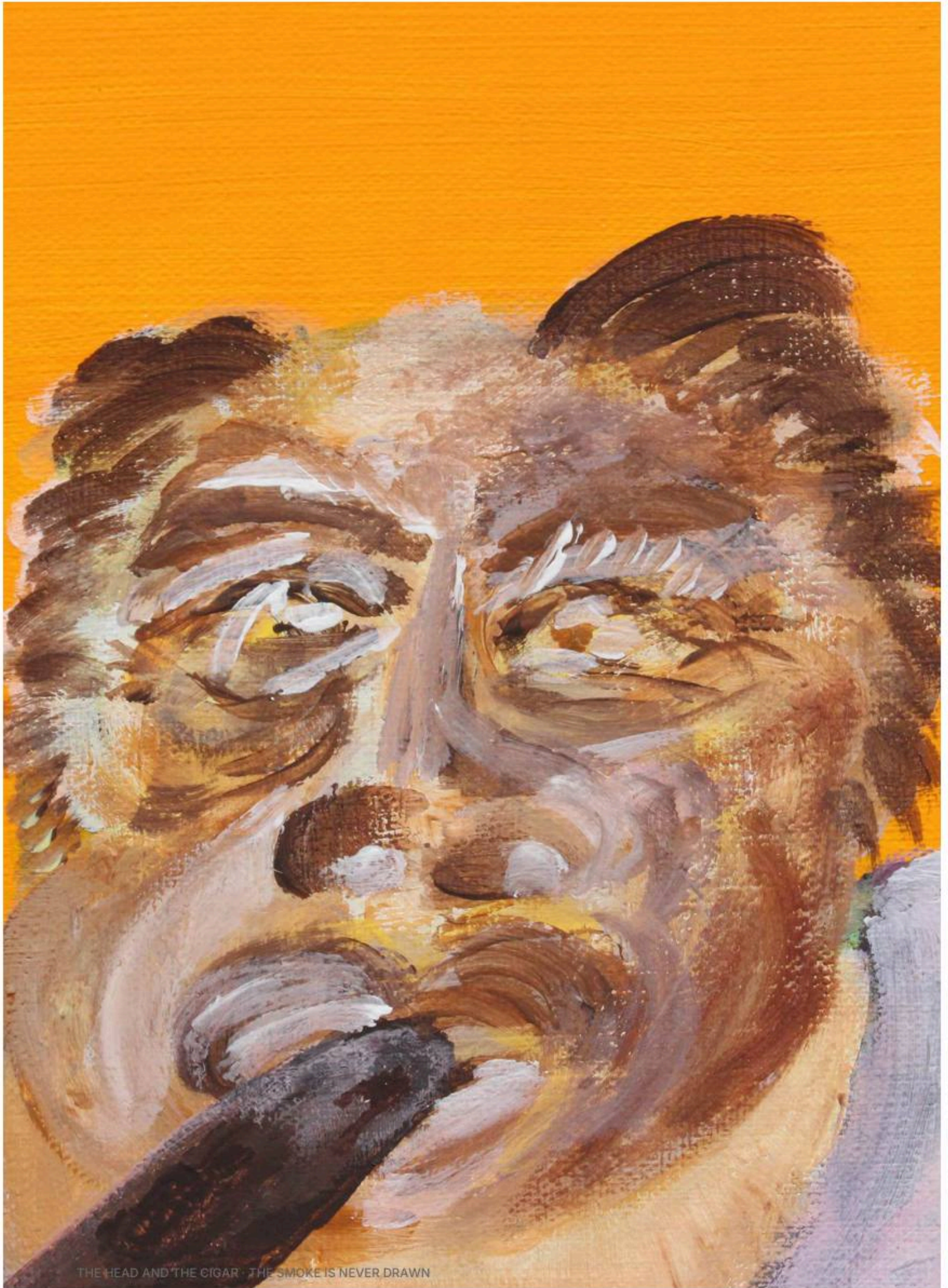
03 · GARY GRILLS COOPER · OPPOSITE · THE HEAD AND THE CIGAR — NINE TENTHS WARM, TWO TURQUOISE SCRATCHES

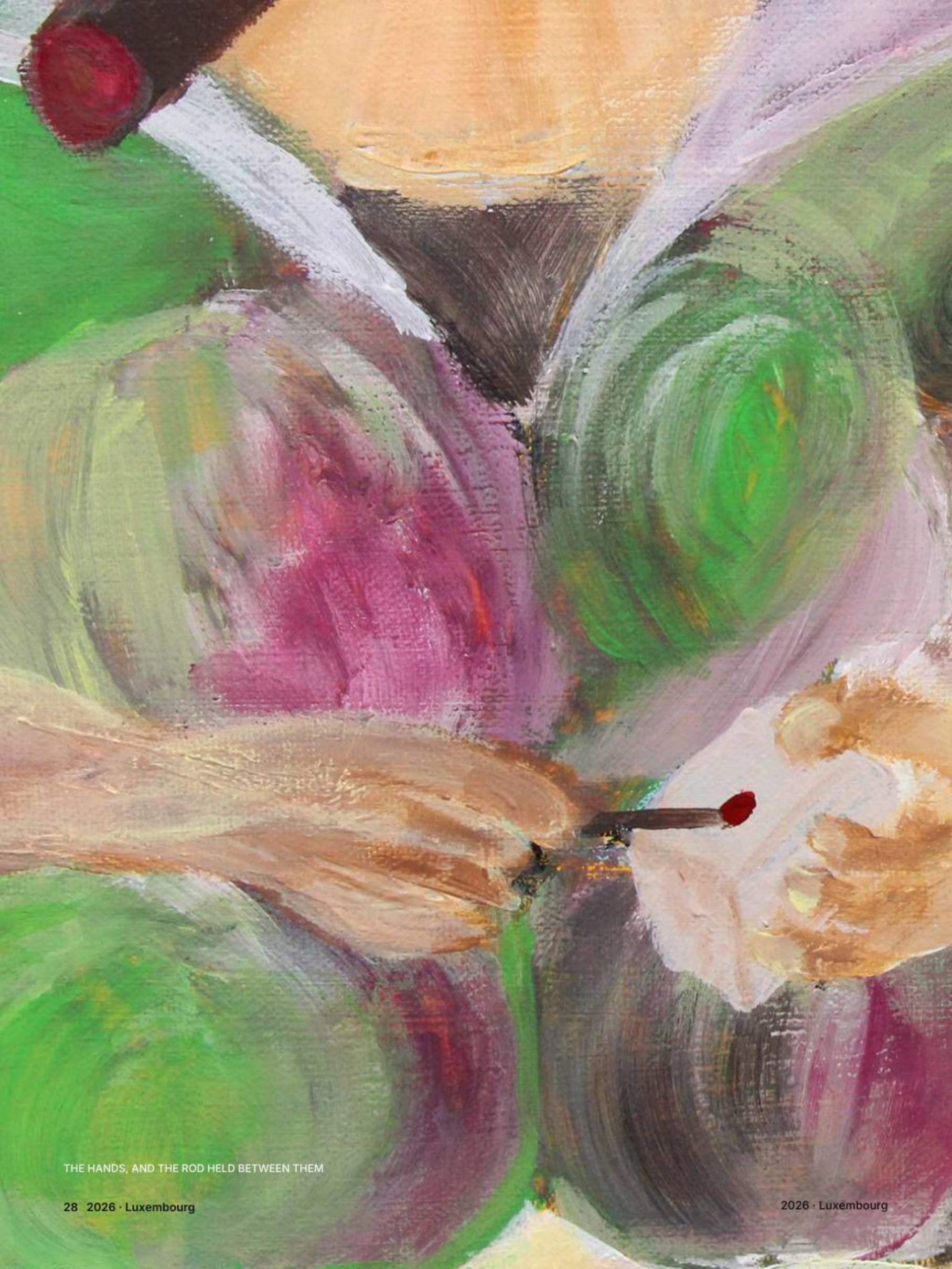
STAGE 1 — THE SOURCE

FIRST FRAME: PRODUCTION STILL, THE SOPRANOS, HBO. COPYRIGHT REMAINS WITH THE RIGHTS HOLDER.

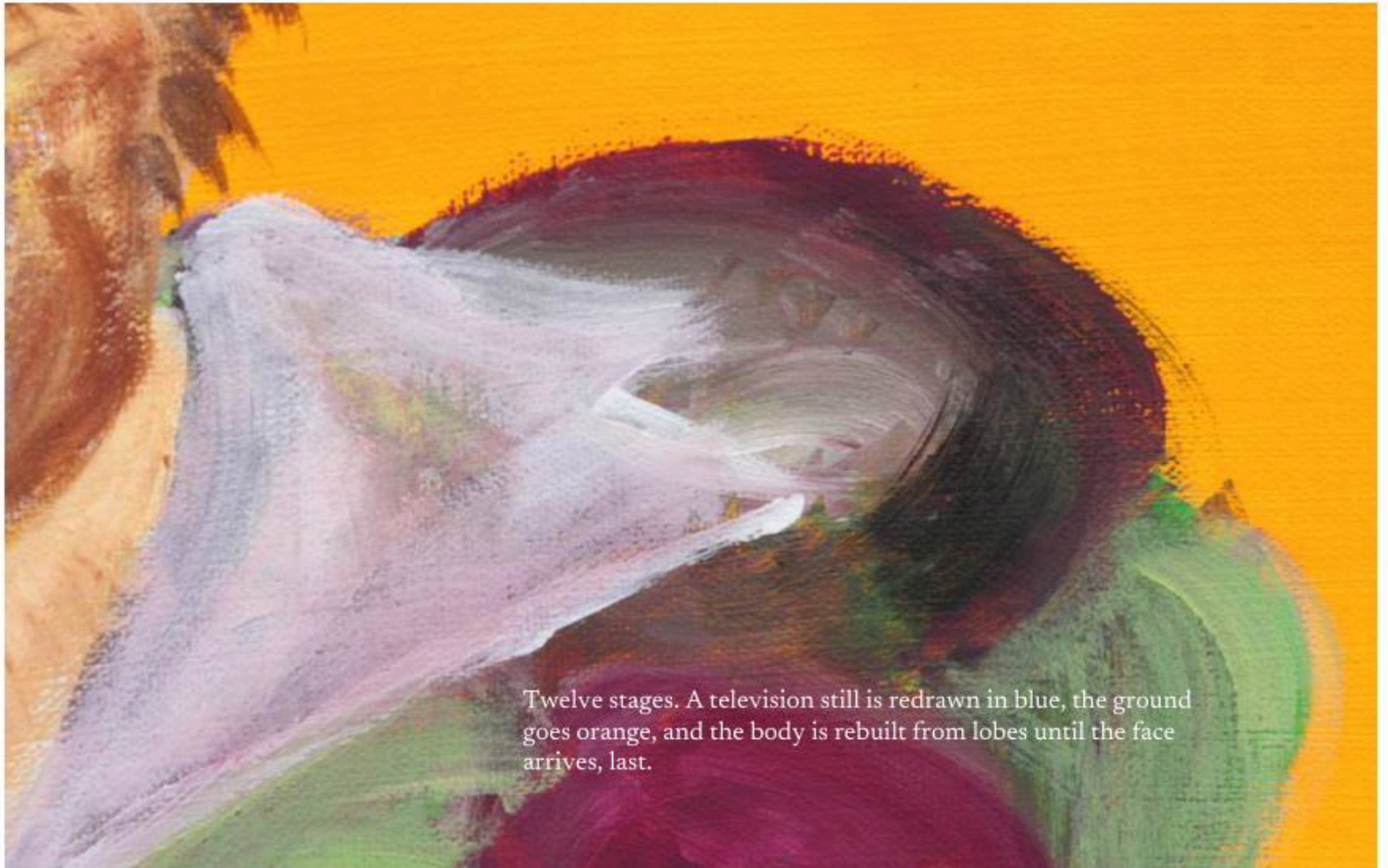
OF 12 STAGES, 6 · IN ORDER





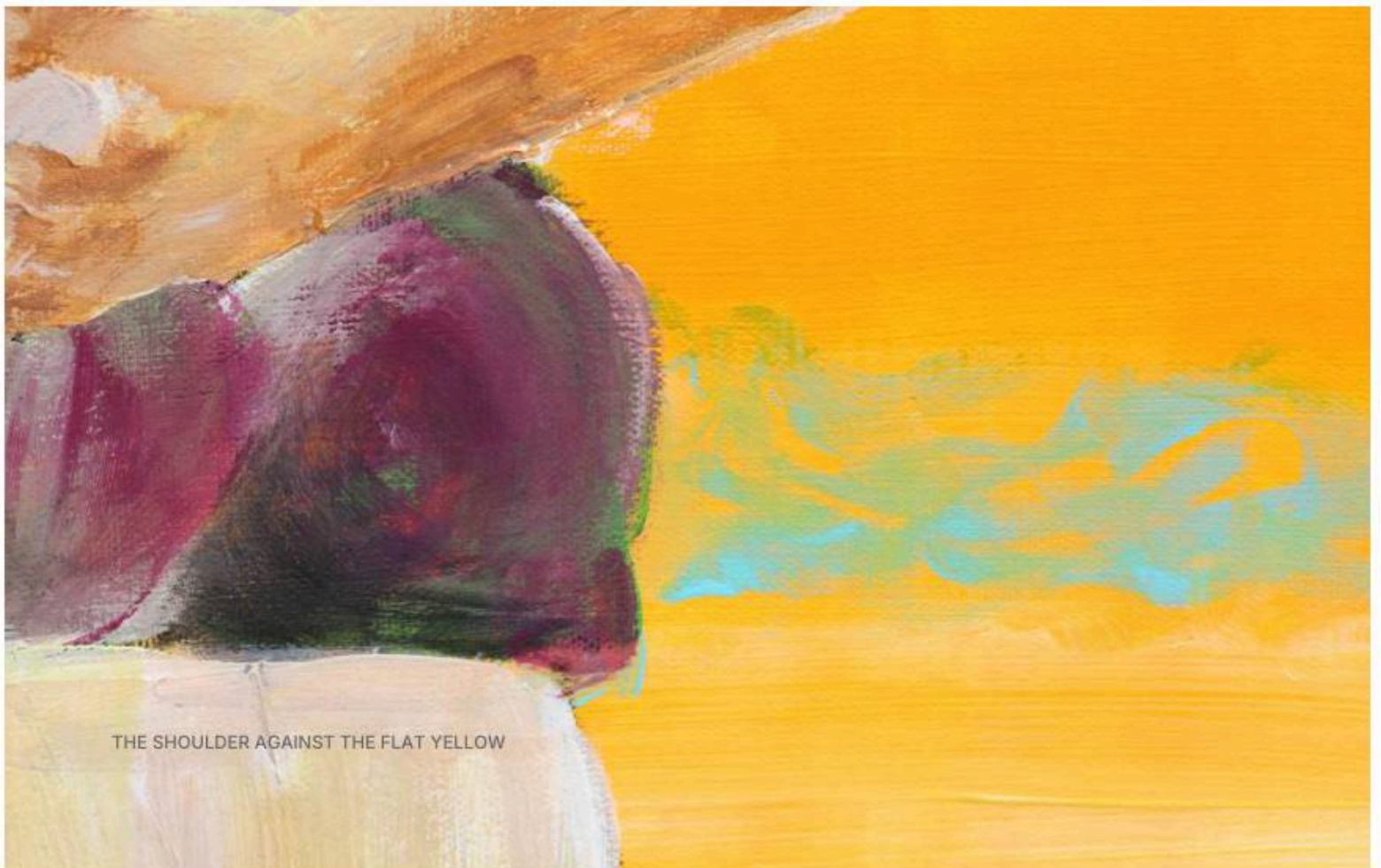


THE HANDS, AND THE ROD HELD BETWEEN THEM



Twelve stages. A television still is redrawn in blue, the ground goes orange, and the body is rebuilt from lobes until the face arrives, last.

THE WHITE CONE AT THE SHOULDER



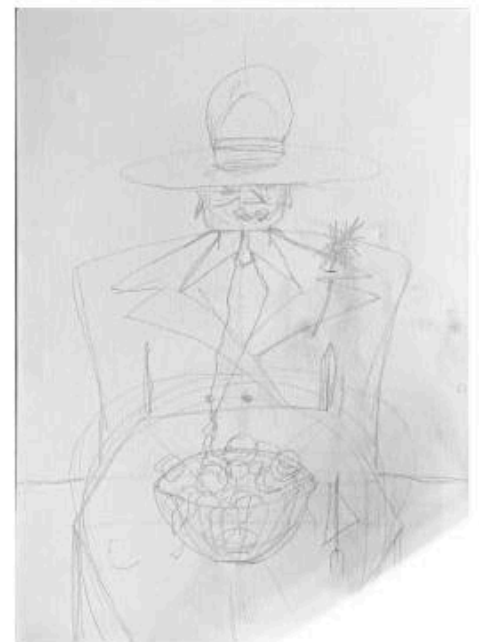
THE SHOULDER AGAINST THE FLAT YELLOW



04 · WALLS OF PERCEPTION · THE BANDED UPPER HALF, AND THE PINK STROKES STANDING UNDER IT



THE YELLOW BURST AGAINST THE RED · THE STUDIES BENEATH IT, IN THE ORDER THEY WERE MADE



The attack comes down the diagonal; the rowers hold their line.

ONE BIRD AT FULL WIDTH — BLUE, GREY, WHITE AND BLACK ONLY, CONTRAST CARRIED BY VALUE AND NOT BY HUE



THE ROW OF FIGURES ON THE BOAT

05 · ARTICULO ATTACK ON MANDARIN · THE BIRDS CLOSING ON THE
MAST, AND THE FIGURES AT THE FOOT OF IT





THE FLOCK, UPPER MIDDLE · BLUE, GREY, WHITE AND BLACK ONLY



THE SAME FLOCK LOWER DOWN, WHERE THE BIRDS MEET THE WATER



THE SAME BOAT DRAWN IN WHITE LINE ONLY, ON A GROUND SCRAPPED FLAT BEFORE THE LINE WAS PUT DOWN



THE SOURCE — JOHN WILLIAM WATERHOUSE, ULYSSES AND THE SIRENS, 1891. THE ROWERS HOLD THEIR LINE WHILE THE BIRDS COME DOWN THE DIAGONAL. PUBLIC DOMAIN



THE STUDY, BEFORE THE BIRDS



THE FULL REIGN: THE BIRDS ABOVE THE BOAT AND ITS ROWERS BELOW



THE DARK UPPER THIRD, THE WATER, AND THE BOAT - THREE BANDS, NO LINE DRAWN BETWEEN THEM





06 · SITILOP · THE PAINTING WHOLE, AFTER THE FOUR DETAILS



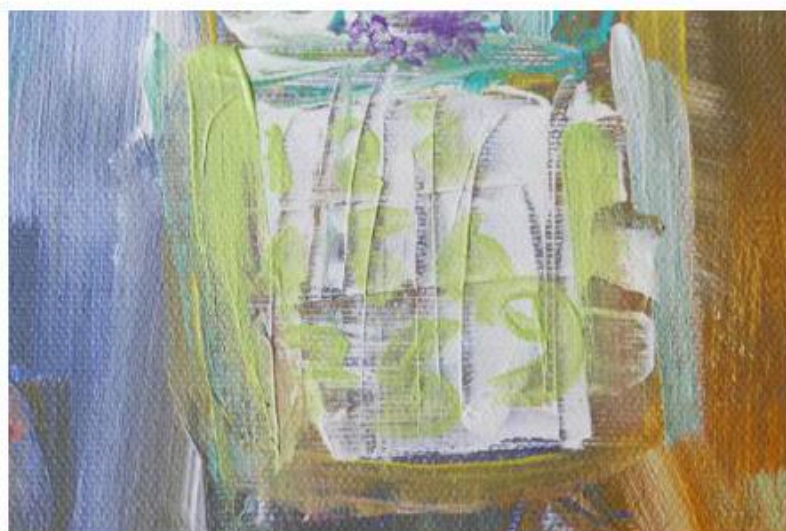
THE HORIZONTAL BAND, AND THE ROW OF NOTCHES STANDING UNDER IT

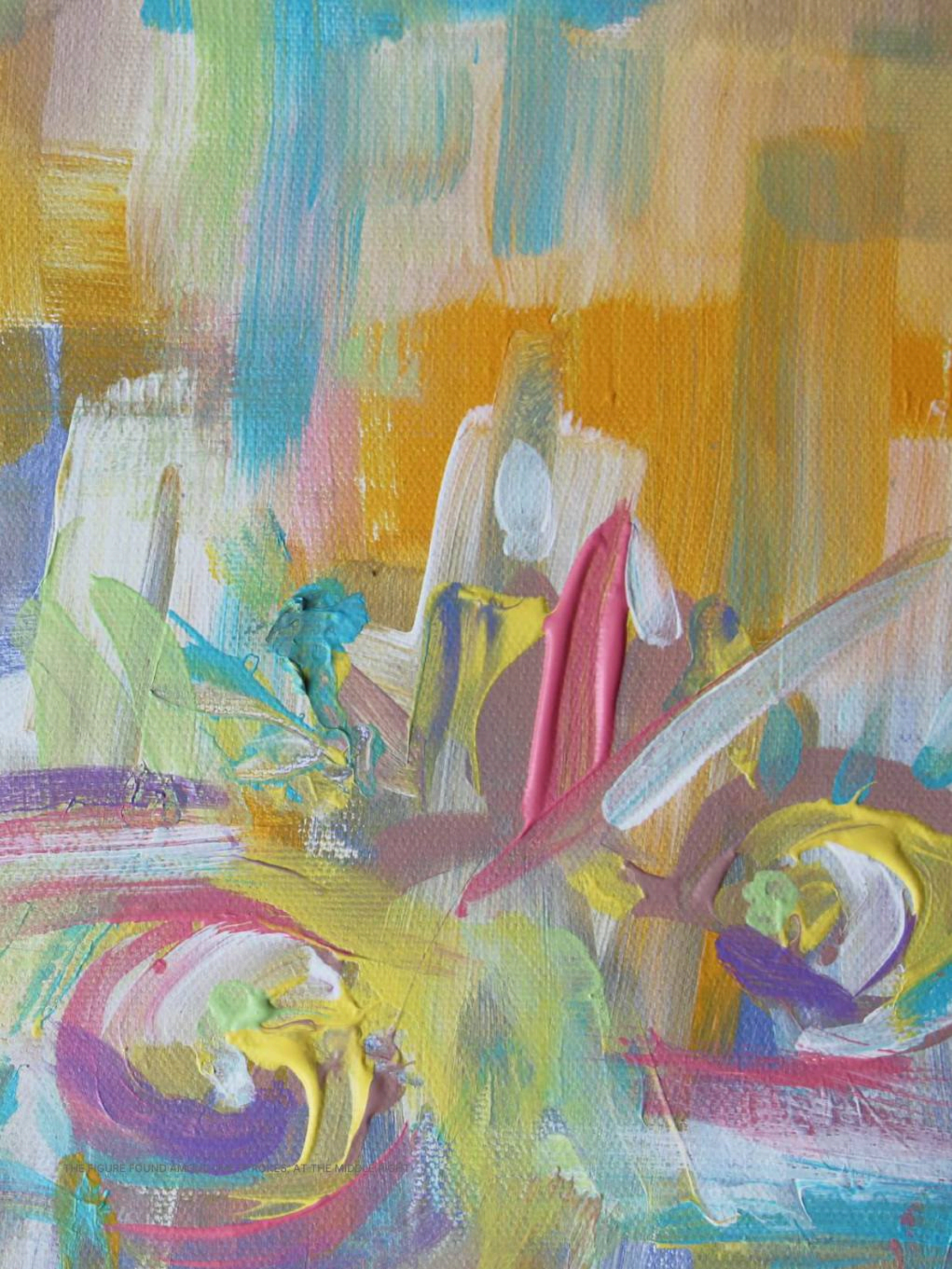
06 · S(T)LOP · OPPOSITE · THE ROUNDED FIELDS, LILAC OVER TURQUOISE — LESS THAN ONE PER CENT BELOW MID VALUE, MUSTARD GOLD RATHER THAN THE PASTELS





THE RIGHT EDGE, FROM THE BARRED FRAME DOWN TO THE PANEL
06 · S(T)LOP · OPPOSITE · THE ORANGE GROUND, AND THE PINK BLADE LAID ACROSS IT — LESS THAN ONE PER CENT
BELOW MID VALUE, MUSTARD GOLD RATHER THAN THE PASTELS





THE FIGURE FOUND AMONG THE STONES, AT THE MIDDLE RIGHT



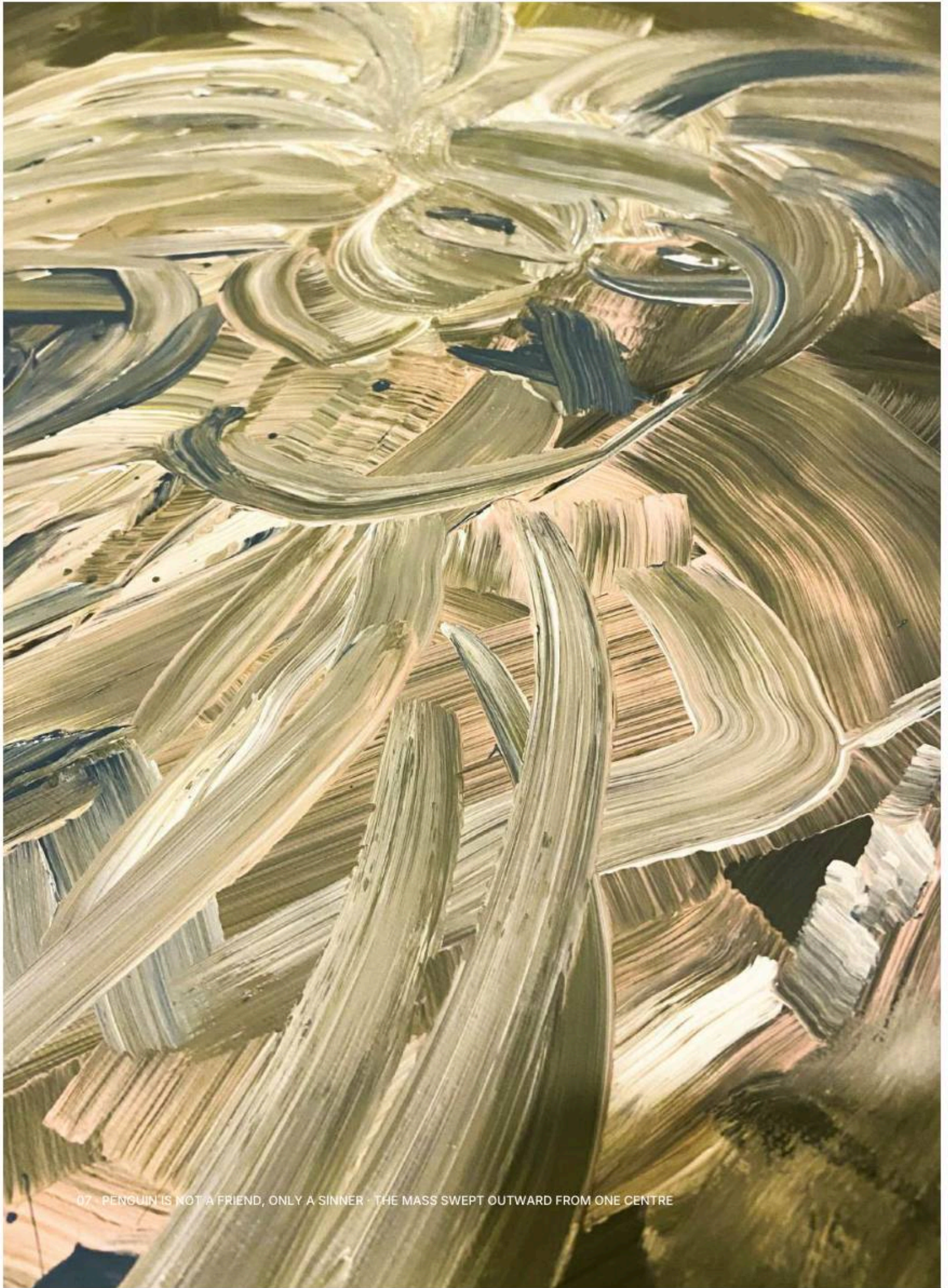
07 · PENGUIN IS NOT A FRIEND, ONLY A SINNER · THE ONE COMMISSION OF THE PAINTING YEARS



BEFORE THE YELLOW · THE WHOLE FIELD WORKED IN WHITE AND GREY OVER THE OCHRE



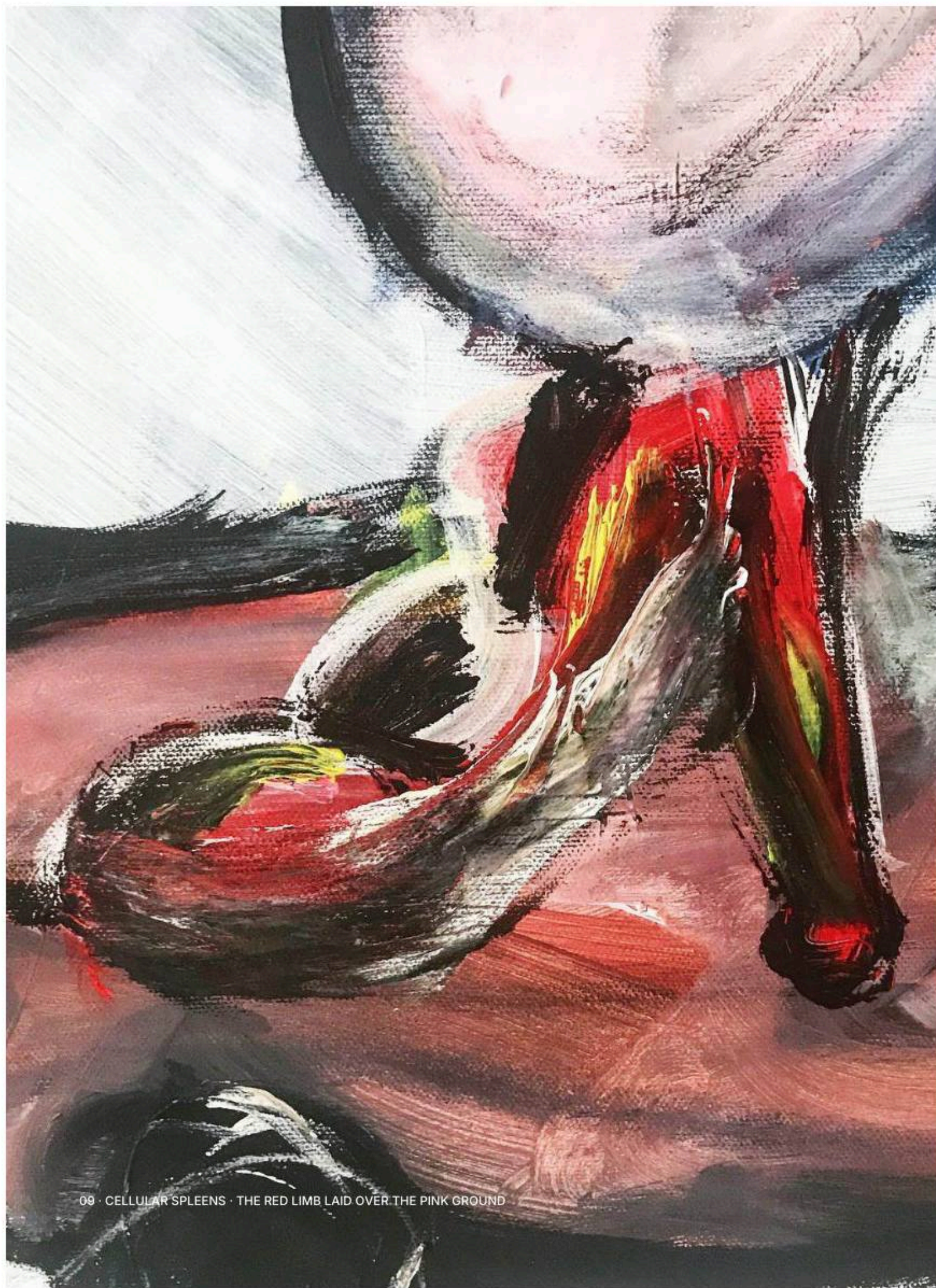
AFTER THE YELLOW · ONE WAY LINE DRAWN THROUGH THE SAME FIELD



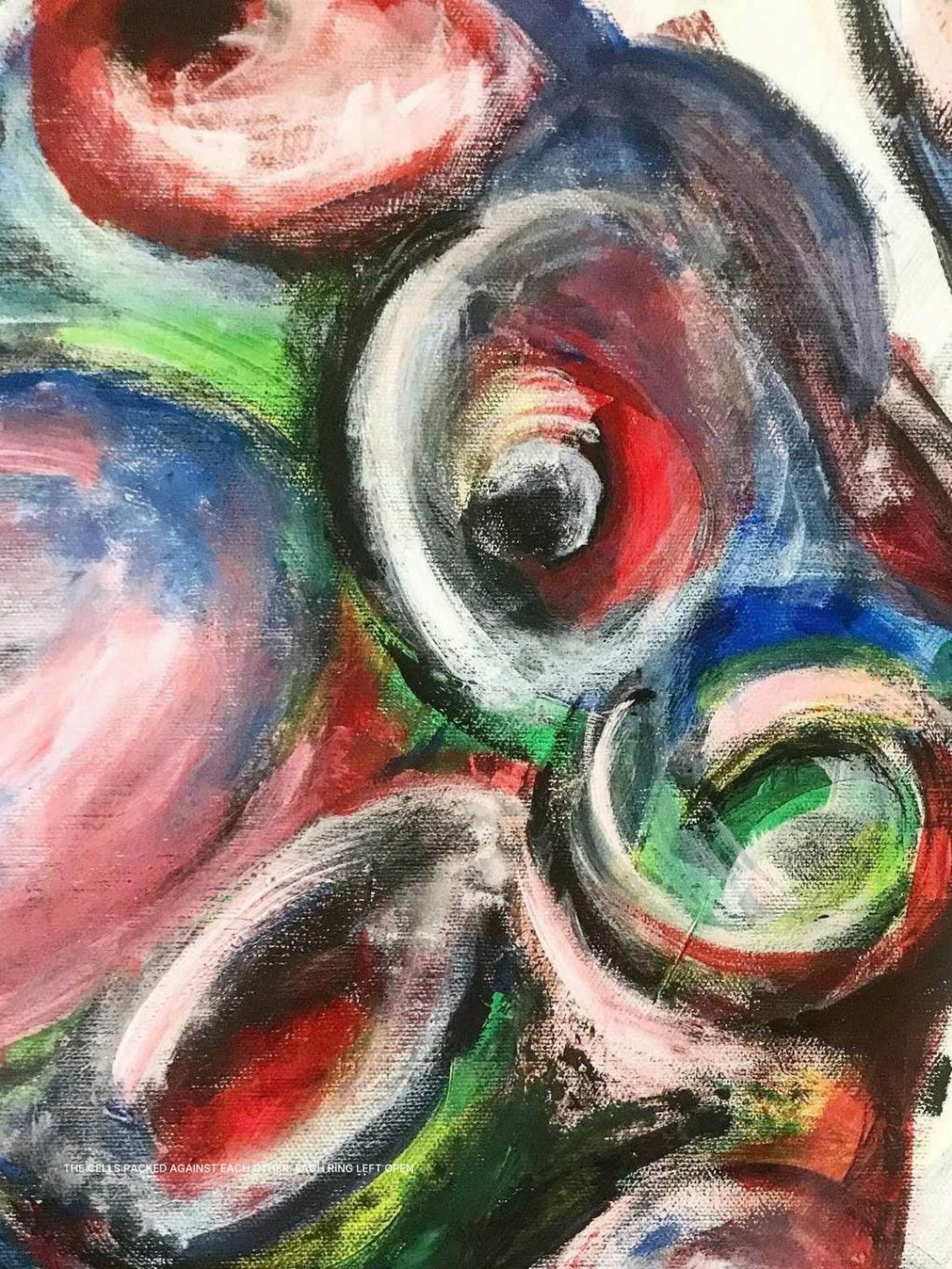
07 PENGUIN IS NOT A FRIEND, ONLY A SINNER · THE MASS SWEEPED OUTWARD FROM ONE CENTRE



THE HEAD AT FULL PAGE · THE SNOUT BROUGHT DOWN, THE GROUND LEFT BARE AND IT



09 · CELLULAR SPLEENS · THE RED LIMB LAID OVER THE PINK GROUND



THE CELLS PACKED AGAINST EACH OTHER, EACH RING LEFT OPEN



10

cute but unemployed cartoon figure

ACRYLIC ON CANVAS · 65 × 90 CM · 25 3/8 × 35 3/8 IN · 2020 · MILAN

The red ground is a single flat layer from end to end, leaving nothing to fill the space around the figure. In the middle a single-coloured field and a creature standing upon it. The unemployment of the title matches precisely this emptiness, a figure with no role in a scene with no set.

COLOUR — ONE RED OVER HALF THE SURFACE, EVERY COLOUR OF THE FIGURE SOILED AGAINST IT
COMPOSITION — A FIGURE STANDING ON NOTHING, THREE OF THE FOUR CORNERS LEFT EMPTY
HAND — ONE COAT OF RED STOPPING AROUND THE FIGURE, LOADED MASSES SET ONTO IT WHILE DRYING

the family dinner after a night in jail

ACRYLIC ON CANVAS · 65 × 90 CM ·
25 3/8 × 35 3/8 IN · 2020 · MILAN

Green has wrapped everything, three heads float within this colour; all three issue from the same mass and mix back into it. The one on the left is the lightest and most luminous, almost phosphorescent, its eye sockets hollowed.

COLOUR — WARM UNDER FIVE IN
TEN THOUSAND, THE WHOLE EVENT
BETWEEN GREEN AND ITS BLUE
NEIGHBOUR
COMPOSITION — THREE UPRIGHT
MASSES DARKENING INTO NAVY
POOLS, WITH NO HORIZONTAL LINE
ANYWHERE
HAND — WET INTO WET
THROUGHOUT, THE ONE HARD EDGE
THE THICK WHITE DOME AT THE
LEFT



caprocorn sister: war, plague, earthquake

ACRYLIC ON CANVAS · 65 × 90 CM · 25 3/8 × 35 3/8 IN · 2020 · MILAN

In the middle of the lower half stands a dark green chest, its edges combed in lines, its lid closed; while everything around it is crooked, it is the one geometric unit. Three bodies are ranged around it and the title lists three catastrophes side by side: war, plague, earthquake.

COLOUR — COOL AT EIGHT NINTHS AND BLUE NEAR TWO THIRDS, THE
LIGHTEST VALUES UNPAINTED CANVAS
COMPOSITION — THREE BODIES AROUND A CUBE AT THREE HEIGHTS, THE
CHEST THE ONE ANGULAR UNIT
HAND — THE NIGHT HATCHED DRY OVER BLACK, BODIES IN THIN HALF
OPAQUE LAYERS THAT LET THE WEAVE BREATHE

When the Darkness surrounds, be among those who burn the Great Fire

ACRYLIC ON CANVAS · 65 x 90 CM · 25 1/8 x 35 3/8 IN · 2020 · MILAN

The hand at the end of the arm reaching to the right is left unable to become a fist, the fingers not quite closed; it could be about to strike, it could be reached out to hold something. The title says be one of those who light the great fire, but the palm is empty, nothing burning is visible in the painting.

COLOUR — WARM OVER TWO THIRDS AND ALL OF IT ON THE FIGURE, THE GROUND A SOILED KHAKI, BROWN AND OLIVE

COMPOSITION — ONE FIGURE FILLING THE FRAME, ITS OPEN HAND THE SINGLE GESTURE

HAND — UNMIXED COLOURS SOILED BY RUBBING ON THE GROUND, THICK WET PAINT FOR THE BODY, NO DRAWN CONTOUR



17

The On-Top Ruler

ACRYLIC ON THICK PAPER · 29.7 × 42 CM · 11 ¾ × 16 ½ IN · 2020 · MILAN

A tower is built of heads heaped one on another and the topmost is the largest of all; between them there is no shoulder or neck, the heads seated directly one upon another.

COLOUR — NEARLY HALF NEUTRAL AND MOST OF THAT BARE PAPER, NO COLOUR FAMILY PAST A TENTH
COMPOSITION — HEADS STACKED WITH NO NECK BETWEEN THEM, THE LARGEST OF ALL AT THE TOP
HAND — THIN HALF OPAQUE ACRYLIC ON THICK PAPER, BLACK LINES ADDED LAST AND CLOSING NOTHING

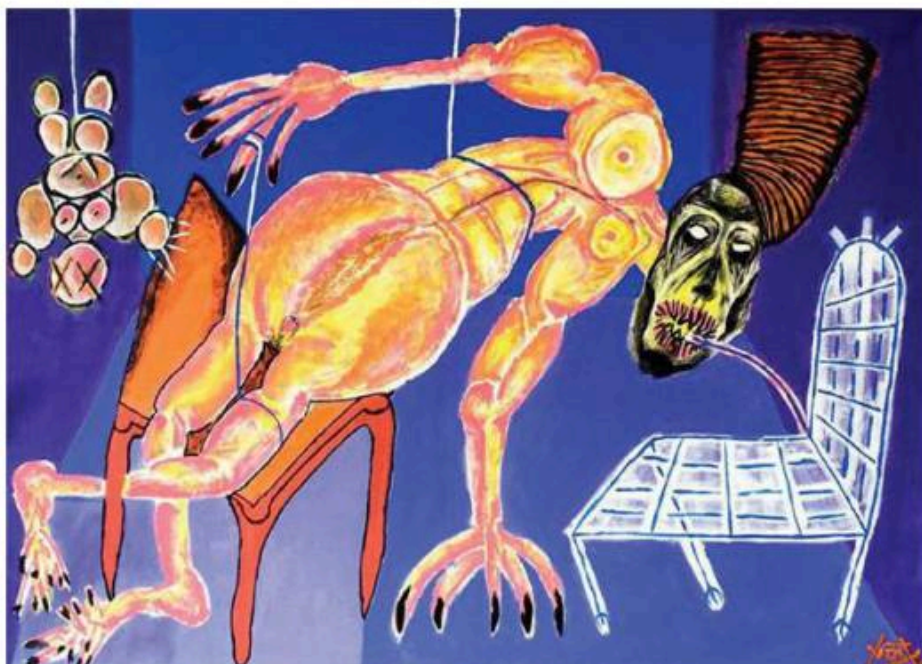
bacchus 2

ACRYLIC ON PAPER · 42 × 59.4 CM · 16 ½ × 23 ¾ IN ·
2020 · MILAN

The inside of the stemmed goblet on the right opens not onto a drink but onto a dark pit spiralling down; the distance between drinking and being swallowed closes. The goblet is almost as large as the head, its thin long stem not looking able to carry a bowl of this breadth, ready to topple and no one holding it.

COLOUR — RED A QUARTER, WORKED AT TWO ENDS,
THE CROWN ABOVE AND THE BORDER BELOW
COMPOSITION — THE SHEET SPLIT IN TWO, THE
HEAD AND THE BOWL OF THE GOBLET AT THE SAME
STEP OF SCALE
HAND — THIN AND DRY ABOVE SO THE PAPER
SHOWS, THICK AND WET BELOW, BLACK CONTOURS
OVER EVERYTHING





22

victim psycho-logique II : the peachy pharaoh connects with the chair

ACRYLIC ON CANVAS · 65 × 90 CM · 25 3/8 × 35 3/8 IN · 2019 · MILAN

A peach-coloured body stands doubled over on a diagonal running from lower left to upper right, its heaviest mass gathered right at the level of the belly, the legs that bear it thin and long; the borne is heavy, the bearer weak.

COLOUR — HALF A SINGLE BLUE PURPLE AGAINST THE PEACH YELLOW BODY,
OPPOSITE ENDS OF THE WHEEL
COMPOSITION — THREE UNITS LEFT TO RIGHT, A HANGING TOY, A BODY
COLLAPSED ON A CHAIR, AN EMPTY CHAIR IN LINE
HAND — FLAT GROUND IN ONE COAT, THE BODY RUBBED SOFT INSIDE A THICK
BLACK CONTOUR, ONE CHAIR UNPAINTED



23

guarding holy mountains from malice

ACRYLIC ON CANVAS · 65 × 90 CM · 25 3/8 × 35 3/8 IN · 2019 · MILAN

On the right three blue figures are ranged side by side, the same height, the same stance, arms interlocked; all three have a cross in their eye. Sightless guards have formed a chain.

COLOUR — FIVE PLANES IN FIVE UNMIXED COLOURS, GREEN UNDER ONE IN A THOUSAND AND ALL OF IT IN ONE TUFT
COMPOSITION — AN INTERIOR BUILT AS PLANES OF COLOUR, SPLIT IN TWO WITH THE MIDDLE LEFT EMPTY
HAND — WIDE FLAT COATS FOR THE PLANES, HUNDREDS OF SEPARATE SHORT PULLS FOR THE MASS AT THE RIGHT

good people helping bad ones (that's why they're bad too)

ACRYLIC ON BLACK PAPER · 70 × 100 CM · 27 ½ × 39 ¾ IN · 2019 · MILAN

How many bodies there are within a white heap cannot be counted;
an arm rises up, a leg hangs from beneath it, in the middle two rounds
resembling a chest overlap and it is unclear whose limb ends where.
The one who helps and the one helped, the one embraced and the one
crushed, melt into the same mass.

COLOUR — A QUARTER STILL BARE BLACK PAPER, A LIGHT COOL MASS ABOVE
AND SATURATED WARM FIGURES BELOW
COMPOSITION — A HORIZONTAL SPLIT, FORMS THAT CANNOT BE RESOLVED
ABOVE, THREE EXACTLY DRAWN FIGURES BELOW
HAND — OPAQUE LIGHT COLOUR STRAIGHT ONTO BLACK PAPER, WET INTO
WET ABOVE, ONE PASS BELOW

morbid forebodings triggered by childish landscape

ACRYLIC ON GREY CARTON · 73 × 80 CM · 28 ¾ × 31 ½ IN · 2019 · MILAN

In the upper right corner stands a tree straight out of a child's notebook: a thin stick of a trunk, a round and puffy greenery at its top. That tree we were all made to draw at school, the most innocent sign saying the world is safe.

COLOUR — AN OLIVE YELLOW BODY AND A BLUE GROUND SPLITTING THE SURFACE, THE DARK END CROWDED BY CONTOURS

COMPOSITION — THE CROWN OF A TREE SEATED ON THE RAISED FOREARM OF THE FIGURE

HAND — OPAQUE ACRYLIC ON GREY CARTON WITH ITS CREAM LEFT SHOWING, THICK CONTOURS AGAINST SHORT TOUCHES

society screwing balance

ACRYLIC ON PAPER · 42 × 59.4 CM · 16 ½ × 23 ¾ IN · 2019 · MILAN

Red stick figures multiply below, more than fifteen, all from a single mould: a round, a vertical line, four sticks. A form repeated this much ceases to be a person and becomes a sign; among them none sees another, some hold hands, some are alone.

COLOUR — BLACK AND WHITE TOGETHER FORTY PER CENT, RED CARRYING EVERY FIGURE AND GREEN THE TWO WINDOWS
COMPOSITION — ONE MODELLED FACE SET AGAINST A DOZEN FIGURES BUILT FROM RINGS
HAND — DRY SCATTERED BLACK OVER EXPOSED PAPER, EVERY RED FIGURE ONE PASS AND NONE CORRECTED



PENCIL STUDY; THE HANGING HEAD, THE SEATED GROUP AND THE GRID BEHIND THEM



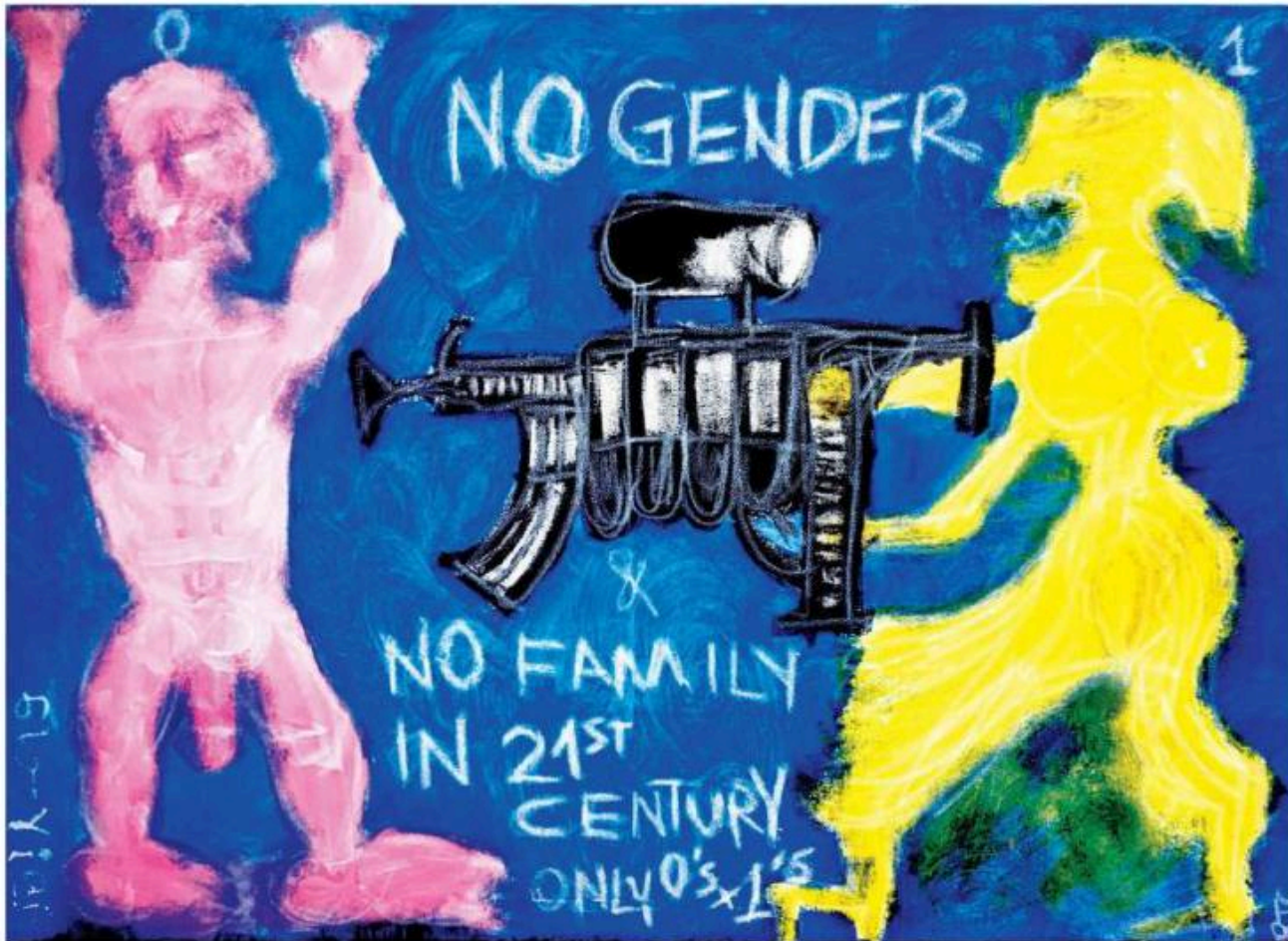
32

How to materialize your loneliness by using an animal in somewhere concrete or technologic

ACRYLIC ON CANVAS · 65 × 90 CM · 25 3/8 × 35 3/8 IN · 2019 · MILAN

On the brow of the enormous head at the left a third eye is opened, and from the two eyes below thick marks descend toward the cheeks. It resembles weeping, but whether what runs is liquid or a scratched-in scratch is unclear.

COLOUR — WARM NEAR TWO THIRDS, WITH DARKNESS AND BRIGHTNESS BOTH FALLING INTO THE RIGHT HALF
COMPOSITION — ONE GIANT HEAD AT THE LEFT AGAINST A CROWDED VERTICAL STRUCTURE AT THE RIGHT
HAND — BRUSH FOR THE WIDE FIELDS, A DRY PASTEL LIKE TIP FOR EVERY LINE AND EVERY WORD



33

Century of 0 & 1 / Transhumanism

ACRYLIC ON CANVAS · 65 × 90 CM · 25 3/8 × 35 3/8 IN · 2019 · MILAN

Hands are raised into the air, palms turned to the front; the oldest sign of surrender and of execution scenes waits on the pink body at the left edge, while opposite, a yellow body in profile, mid-step, extends its arms forward and binds itself to the weapon in its hand.

COLOUR — BLUE OVER HALF THE FIELD, THE BLACK AND WHITE WEAPON OUTSIDE THE COLOUR ORDER ENTIRELY
COMPOSITION — THREE VERTICAL REGIONS, TWO FIGURES AND THE INSTRUMENT THAT BRIDGES THEM
HAND — WIDE CIRCULAR BLUE, A SOFT DRY MATERIAL FOR THE FIGURES, A SHARP CORRECTED LINE FOR THE WEAPON

two woman figures sitting at the back of the canvas

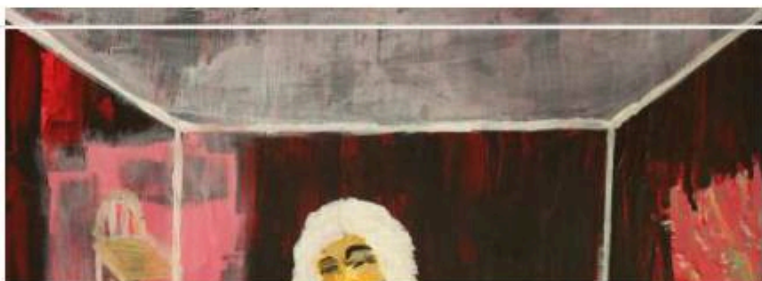
CHARCOAL ON THE REVERSE OF CANVAS · 65 × 90 CM · 25 3/8 × 35 3/8 IN · 2019
· MILAN

The stretcher bars and the central rail are visible just as they are; two female figures are drawn in charcoal on the unpainted back face of the canvas, that is the side normally left turned to the wall.

COLOUR — NO PAINT AT ALL, THE RANGE RUNNING BETWEEN CHARCOAL
BLACK AND RAW CLOTH WHITE
COMPOSITION — THE STRETCHER CROSSBAR DIVIDING THE BACK INTO TWO
EQUAL PANELS, ONE FIGURE IN EACH
HAND — CHARCOAL ON UNPRIMED CLOTH, HOLDING TO THE CRESTS OF THE
WEAVE WITH NO BINDER



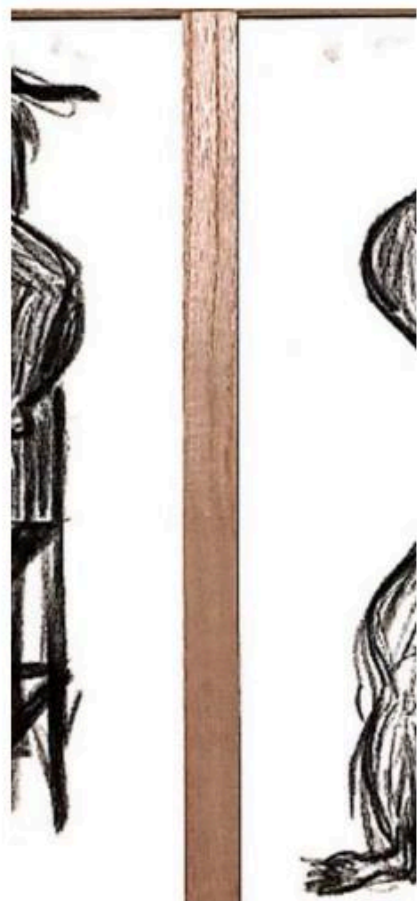
What comes back



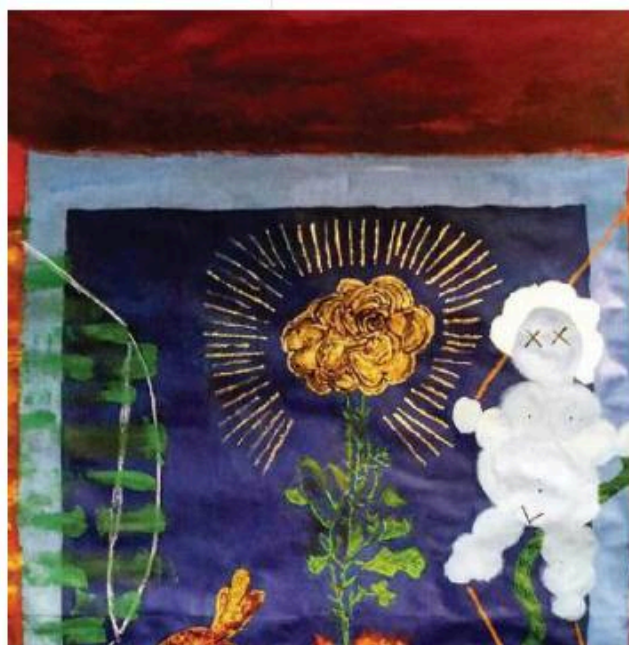
02 · 2026 — THE BOX DRAWN FROM ABOVE, ITS WALLS NEVER ARRIVING



06 · 2026 — A RECTANGLE OF BARS, HUNG AT THE CORNER



35 · 2019 — THE STRETCHER BAR, DIVIDING THE BACK INTO TWO ROOMS



20 · 2019 — A PANEL FRAMED INSIDE THE PICTURE